

S04-04 - The Keystone Reveal

Player read-aloud

Inside the sealed crate is a massive stone with a lion's face carved into it. The room goes quiet before anyone speaks.

Scene summary

The crate contains the Keystone Asset / ward-stone tied to major protective infrastructure.

Visible choices

- Ask why it was hidden
- Accuse Emeris
- Agree to help
- Refuse danger

Player questions

- What detail in The Keystone Reveal tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

Raw source

- Id: S04-04
- Act: Act Four
- Title: The Keystone Reveal
- Beats: Lore reveal GM-only truth Corporate satire beat Emotional beat
- Image: assets/scenes/S04-04-the-keystone-reveal.png
- Short: The crate contains the Keystone Asset / ward-stone tied to major protective infrastructure.
- Long: This is the turn. The job was never ordinary. The corporation concealed a ward failure because public knowledge would invite panic, predators, and acquisition.
- Read: Inside the sealed crate is a massive stone with a lion's face carved into it. The room goes quiet before anyone speaks.
- Gm: This is where Marlowe realizes how much was withheld from her too, unless you want her to know already.
- Entities: Keystone Asset Marlowe Fairwind Whitefire Custodian Emeris Crown Holdings Goldspire Territories Open Vale Ward Lines Ward Stability Track Sealed Keystone Crate Dustless Ward Map Ward Renewal Chime Difficulty Ladder Stress Hush Fear
- Choices: Ask why it was hidden Accuse Emeris Agree to help Refuse danger
- Prompt: Interior of cluttered magical maintenance office; Custodian opens sealed crate with glowing ward-stone carved with lion face; adventurers realize job is bigger; no strixwolf, no Bramble Union, no undead.
- Source Entities: Keystone Asset Marlowe Fairwind Whitefire Custodian Emeris Crown

Holdings

- Beat Codes: lore-reveal gm-only-truth corporate-satire-beat emotional-beat
- Slug: S04-04-the-keystone-reveal
- Act Title: The Hanging Office
- Arc Role: Mentor-custodian truth reveal
- Caption: The Keystone Asset stops being cargo and becomes a communal protection problem.
- Image Alt: The Keystone Reveal scene art for The Hanging Office.
- Image Prompt Used: Interior of cluttered magical maintenance office; Custodian opens sealed crate with glowing ward-stone carved with lion face; adventurers realize job is bigger; no strixwolf, no Bramble Union, no undead. Do not include the Strixwolf Mother, strixwolf pups, wolves, owlbeats, or animal companions unless explicitly requested. No strixwolf, no Bramble Union, no undead. Focus on the Custodian and the Keystone Asset reveal. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: This is the turn. The job was never ordinary. The corporation concealed a ward failure because public knowledge would invite panic, predators, and acquisition. Run this scene as mentor-custodian truth reveal: The Keystone Asset stops being cargo and becomes a communal protection problem. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: Inside the sealed crate is a massive stone with a lion's face carved into it. The room goes quiet before anyone speaks.
- Gm Notes: This is where Marlowe realizes how much was withheld from her too, unless you want her to know already. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic. [KEEP/GUARANTEED] The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. [ADD/SEED] "Your capital's safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear." [ADD/EARNED] The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive. (Knowledge Hard 20)
- Sensory Details: stone heartbeat ward lines brightening under dust a low tone felt in teeth
- Body Language: Marlowe looks guilty before she looks relieved The Custodian touches the crate like an apology
- Sample Dialogue: Whitefire Custodian They called it an asset because 'borrowed safety' tested poorly in stakeholder review.
- Checks: Knowledge Understand the ward-stone without changing module mechanics. Standard The party learns what must be defended. 15 Cleanly resolve: Understand the ward-stone without changing module mechanics. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to The Keystone Reveal. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to expose neglected infrastructure, stress the Custodian, or make the Keystone hum at the wrong moment. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers:

visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.

- Choices Consequences: Accept the broader duty The party pivots from delivery to protection. Ward Stability track opens. Stay narrowly hired Still proceed, but framed as risk management. Epilogue may challenge them.
- Clues: Keystone pulse The crate protects Hush. Corporate custody is administratively convenient, not morally clean. It responds to ward stress, not ownership. Guaranteed seed The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. Earned seed Available if players investigate, show mercy, or ask the right question. The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive. Knowledge Hard 20
- Loot: Keystone handling instructions Ward map copy Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out. Whitefire Custodian's Ward-Charm: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-scamper has been thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a little kinder while you hold it.
- Payoff Flags: Custodian Trust Track Ward Stability Track
- Filters: act-four choice corporate-satire-beat custodian-trust-track emotional-beat gm-only gm-only-truth lore-reveal the-hanging-office ward-stability-track npc manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned clue
- Index: 16
- Player Questions: What detail in The Keystone Reveal tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownership Prompt: Name one detail in The Keystone Reveal that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Reveal Hooks: Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.
- Fear Spends: Spend Fear to expose neglected infrastructure, stress the Custodian, or make the Keystone hum at the wrong moment. Make neglected infrastructure answer at the wrong moment. Stress the Custodian's trust without turning her into a device.
- Story Scope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The sealed package is the

capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. KEEP GUARANTEED "The wood never needed managing. It needed leaving alone." ADD SEED "Your capital's safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear."

ADD SEED The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive. ADD EARNED Knowledge Hard 20 The Custodian glances at obsolete Soulspire inspection seals on her counterweight boulder. ADD EARNED

Instinct Medium 15 The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. KEEP GUARANTEED "Your capital's safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear." ADD SEED The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive.

ADD EARNED Knowledge Hard 20 Presence: earn candor. Knowledge...

- Mechanics: The party is in Act Four pressure: The crate contains the Keystone Asset / ward-stone tied to major protective infrastructure. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting.
s04-04-recognize-the-keystone S04-04 Recognize the Keystone Recognize the Keystone Knowledge Knowledge None 12 Knowledge connects heraldry, wardcraft, and custody. The party carries a capital crisis without understanding it. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party carries a capital crisis without understanding...

- Roll Cards: s04-04-recognize-the-keystone S04-04 Recognize the Keystone Recognize the Keystone Knowledge Knowledge None 12 Knowledge connects heraldry, wardcraft, and custody. The party carries a capital crisis without understanding it. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The party carries a capital crisis without understanding it. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time, noise, leverage...

- Conditions Hazards: No official condition unless a feature, hazard, or fictional position calls for Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable.
- Search Loot Clues: Keystone handling: warning label, hum, possible splinter only on remarkable care.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: The Keystone Reveal asks what the party does, what

it costs, and who is protected.

- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Finesse, Instinct, Knowledge. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Factionids: emeris-crown-holdings
- World Connection Prompts: S04-04-emeris-crown-holdings-world-connection emeris-crown-holdings Emeris Crown Holdings You have worked a job like this before. What is the part of the contract you learned to read twice?
- Location Ids: goldspire-territories open-vale-ward-lines
- Item Ids: keystone-asset whitefire-ward-charm
- Clueids: public-private-ward-compact dustless-ward-map the-pre-dated-invoice the-convenient-renewal the-ward-subscription the-cheerful-ledger
- Clue Ids: public-private-ward-compact dustless-ward-map the-pre-dated-invoice the-convenient-renewal the-ward-subscription the-cheerful-ledger
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